CHEAT SHEET

AI Safety Checklist

Your practical guide to using AI confidently

Congratulations on completing Module 4. You earned this.

1 Never Share With AI

These items should never be typed into any AI chatbot — free or paid.

Social Security Number (SSN)	No legitimate AI task requires it. Keep this offline entirely.
Passwords or PINs	For any account, device, or system. No exceptions.
Bank / Routing Numbers	Bank account or routing numbers of any kind.
Credit / Debit Card Numbers	Including CVV codes. There is no valid reason to give these to an AI.
Medical Records / Diagnoses	Symptoms are usually fine; full records are not. Don't paste charts or lab results.
Private Photos of Others	Especially photos of minors. You do not own their data.
Confidential Work Documents	Contracts, internal memos, client data, trade secrets — off limits.
Passport / License Numbers	Government ID numbers of any kind belong offline.
Immigration Status	This information is sensitive in any context. Keep it out of AI tools entirely.
Login Credentials	Email, banking, social media — never type these into an AI chatbox.

Why: *Even well-designed AI systems store conversation data for training and review. There is no guarantee your input stays private.*

2 Think Twice Before Sharing

These are okay in some situations, but carry real risk depending on context and platform.

Full Name + Location Together	Either alone is usually fine; combined they create a searchable profile of you.
Employer + Internal Details	Mentioning your industry is low risk; specific project names or client names may violate NDAs.
Children's Names / School Details	Vague references are fine; specifics build a profile of a minor without their consent.
Ongoing Legal Situations	AI can explain general law; sharing case-specific details is risky and potentially harmful.
Details About Other People	Asking AI to help draft a message about a coworker shares their information without their knowledge or consent.
Family Members' Health Conditions	General questions are fine; detailed family medical history is not yours to share.
Financial Situation Specifics	General budgeting questions are fine; exact income, debt amounts, or account balances are not.

Rule of thumb: *Ask yourself — "If this conversation were printed and left on a coffee shop table, would I be uncomfortable?" If yes, leave it out.*

3 Generally Safe to Share

These types of information carry low risk and are what AI tools are designed to help with.

General How-To Questions	"How do I write a cover letter?" or "What's the best way to cook chicken?" — totally fine.
Creative Writing and Fiction	Characters, plots, made-up worlds — AI thrives here. No personal data involved.
Publicly Available Information	Things you'd find on Wikipedia or in a news article. Already out there.
Hypothetical Scenarios	"What would happen if a city banned cars?" or "Write a story about a robot."
Learning and Research Topics	History, science, math, languages — this is where AI genuinely excels.
Your General Profession or Industry	"I work in healthcare" or "I'm a small business owner" — no sensitive specifics attached.
Editing and Proofreading	Drafts of emails, resumes, or letters that contain no sensitive data or other people's information.
Ideas and Brainstorming	Product names, event planning, gift ideas — AI is a great sounding board here.

4 How to Spot AI-Generated Fakes

The tells are consistent. Once you know them, they're hard to unsee.

FAKE IMAGES — LOOK FOR:

Wrong Number of Fingers	AI frequently gets hands wrong. Count them — extra fingers, missing joints, or merged digits are dead giveaways.
Blurry or Nonsensical Text	Any text inside a generated image will be blurry, misspelled, or completely made-up when you zoom in.
Impossible Backgrounds	Architecture that curves oddly, trees that merge into each other, floors that don't line up.
Asymmetrical Details	Ears, hair, and jewelry that are lopsided or seem to dissolve into the background around the edges.
Glassy Eyes / Wrong Reflections	Eyes that look slightly artificial, or reflect light from two completely different directions.
Generator Watermarks	Faint logos from image generators — look in corners or along the edges of the image.

FAKE TEXT AND ARTICLES — LOOK FOR:

No Author, Date, or Source	Missing any of these is a red flag. Real journalism has real bylines and real timestamps.
Unnaturally Smooth Writing	Never uses contractions or casual phrases. Human writing has rhythm, imperfections, and personality. AI writing is often frictionless in a way that feels off.
Claims With No Evidence Links	Sounds plausible, but every factual claim floats free with nothing to verify it against.
Unverifiable Stats or Quotes	If you can't find who said it or where the number came from, be skeptical. AI invents citations.

DEEPFAKE VIDEO AND AUDIO — LOOK FOR:

Lip Sync Mismatch	Mouth movements that don't quite match the words — especially noticeable on longer syllables.

Unnatural Blinking	Either too frequent or not frequent enough. Real people blink in a surprisingly consistent rhythm.
Lighting That Doesn't Match	The light on the face doesn't match the environment behind the person — usually subtle but visible.
Blurry Face Edges	Warping or blurring around the face, ears, or hairline — especially during motion.
Flat Voice Quality	Real voices have breath, hesitation, and natural variation. AI voice sounds slightly too clean or robotic in transitions.

AI VOICE CLONE SCAM CALLS — WATCH FOR:

Fake Distress from "Family"	A caller who sounds like a family member or coworker claiming to be in trouble and asking for money or personal info.
Urgency and Pressure	"Don't tell anyone, just send money now." Real emergencies allow time for verification.
Voice That Feels Slightly Off	Sounds right but has small pauses, robotic transitions, or missing emotional variation.
No Family Code Word Known	Establish a private code word with close family for emergencies. Real family will know it. Scammers won't.

5 Your 30-Second Verification Routine

When you see something suspicious — alarming photo, shocking headline, viral video — run through this before sharing.

1 Check the source

Who published this? Is it a site you recognize? Look for an About page, a real author name, and a publication date. If any of those are missing, pause.

2 Reverse image search

Right-click the image on desktop and select "Search image" — or drag it into images.google.com. If the same image appears on unrelated stories from years ago, it's been recycled or fabricated.

3 Look for the original

Search for the story on Google News. If multiple credible outlets cover it, it's more likely real. If only one site has it, or every result is a copy of the same post, be skeptical.

4 When in doubt, don't share

You are not obligated to pass along information you can't verify. Sitting on a story for 24 hours costs you nothing. Spreading a fabricated photo or quote can reach thousands.

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6 Free vs. Paid — What's Different About Privacy

The tier you use affects how your conversations may be handled.

Platform	Free Tier	Paid Tier
ChatGPT (OpenAI)	Conversations may be used to train future models by default. You can opt out in Settings → Data Controls.	Same opt-out available. Enterprise plans include stronger data protections; training use is off by default for paid API customers.
Claude (Anthropic)	Free conversations may be reviewed by humans for safety and quality. Not used for training by default on the consumer app.	Similar to free tier for the consumer app. Enterprise and API plans include stricter data handling agreements.
Gemini (Google)	Free conversations are reviewed by humans and may improve Google's products. Tied to your Google account.	Google One AI Premium subscribers get stricter privacy controls. Workspace customers have enterprise-grade protections.

The bottom line: Paid tiers generally give you more control, but always check the current privacy settings in your account — they change. The safest assumption on any free AI tool is that human reviewers may read your conversations. That's not an alarm — it's just a reason to keep sensitive information out.

Being careful doesn't mean being afraid.

AI is a tool — knowing how to use it safely makes it more useful, not less. You don't need to avoid AI; you just need to know what belongs in the conversation and what doesn't. The habits in this checklist take seconds to build and protect you for years.